

Interview with Kevin Williams

December 6, 2025

Megan Palmer: [00:00:00] So, hello! Today I am here speaking with Kevin Williams. It is December 6th, 2025 for the Everyday Harmony Oral History Project, where I, Megan Palmer, am talking to everyday barbershoppers about their experiences with the style, culture, and community of barbershop music. We are recording in the chapel of Union Congregational Church before a Voices United rehearsal. Kevin's been a barbershopper for almost 20 years, and I'm so excited to learn more about your barbershop journey today. Thank you so much for talking to me.

Kevin Williams: [00:00:32] Yeah, happy to help.

Megan: [00:00:33] Absolutely. So, I would love to start by asking, like, what was your first encounter with barbershop? How old were you? Like, what was your first impression?

Kevin: [00:00:44] So, it was super brief. For one concert in high school, our choral director decided that he wanted to introduce a barbershop piece. I think it was because he had the right combination of voices in the ensemble, and it just felt right. So, I couldn't even tell you what the piece was, I don't remember, but it was also a— my first experience was in a mixed quartet. So, we had three female-identifying individuals and myself singing bass as part of that ensemble. You know, very cool, very interesting, very unique. I wish there was more follow-up after it, you know, to touch base, particularly with some barbershoppers and people who would, like, encourage it. But during that time— this is the early 80s — there wasn't much push, at least at that level. So it was fun, I enjoyed it, but it was kind of that little fleeting moment.

Megan: [00:01:41] Was— so your choral director wasn't necessarily like a barbershopper; they were just [like] "This is a barbershop style of music and we're going to sing it for a concert."

Kevin: [00:01:51] Exactly. You know, he himself was not a barbershopper or anything. He was just — it was part of his rotation of, "I'm looking to introduce different styles to help my students understand different forms and different frameworks," so.

Megan: [00:02:04] Cool. But it sounds like, despite your 'barbershop moment' kind of being fleeting, that you had a pretty musical childhood; can you tell me a little bit about that?

Kevin: [00:02:14] Sure. So, like a lot of people that perform, whether vocally or instrumentally, you know, started elementary school and choral choirs and, choruses growing up. In fourth grade, it was

1976 is the bicentennial year in the U.S., and [I] was one of three students who wrote lyrics to a song that our choral director then set to music that we then performed as a chorus. So, that was a wild experience.

Megan: [00:02:44] Do you remember the song?

Kevin: [00:02:46]: I remember it was USA's 200th year was, oh, I don't remember everything beyond that. I'm actually horrible at memories, particularly like, you know, childhood; I know this. I admire people that come back, "Oh yeah. In third grade, I, you know, was in this classroom and it was this color paint in the room and you know, whatever." No, I'm not. That's not me. Okay. but, and then continue to sing through middle school, high school had a brilliant choral director, Jim Rakean, who actually my two older kids had as their choral director before he retired.

Megan: Very cool.

Kevin: [00:03:15] Yeah. So that was that was wild. [I] was an all state base in high school, earned our national state floral award in my senior year with the chorus because, you know, I, as I do today was a sucker for volunteering, so did a lot to support the chorus in addition. So yeah. So I sang in high school. College for me was like this brilliant flash and flare out. I was only in college for like a semester and a half before things bottomed out. But while I was there— I was at University at Connecticut, I sang in concert choir, got to do some really creative things there. We had a we had a Jewish Sabbath piece that was written for the choir that we did. So I got to learn some Hebrew through that process and, and, you know, sang that way. And then, you know, the traditional college choir blend of a variety of pieces of classical music. So I did take piano lessons too, growing up.

Kevin: [00:03:15] Somewhere along the line, I just decided vocal is where I was going to focus. Could I figure out something? Yes. Does it help? Yes. Well, and it helps in terms of being able to read music, which I know a lot of barbershoppers are not necessarily in that same place. So I don't read it fast, but I can identify key signatures. I can identify the notes. So that helps accelerate the learning curve. So the theory part of learning piano is super helpful.

Megan: [00:04:51] Cool. So at what point then did you like 'rediscover' barbershop or discover barbershop as an organization and a community and not just a style? Like, how did you officially get involved?

Kevin: [00:05:06] So I'm sure I'm not alone in this. I know a lot of other people who have been in this scenario: I was singing in a church choir, and one of the tenors in the church choir was singing lead, with the Silk City Chorus in Manchester, Connecticut and kept saying, "You've got to come to rehearsal. You got to come. You got to come. You got to come." So, eventually it wore me down. I went

to a rehearsal. And the rehearsal was great, it was fun, but probably the thing that nailed it was after rehearsal, singing a tag. And so that first tag experience was just, "Okay. Yeah. I got to keep doing this." And I haven't looked back.

Megan: [00:05:42] Tell me a little bit more about that first tag. Like, was it just the harmony or was it the community? Like, what was that moment of like learning your very first tag like?

Kevin: [00:05:53] Yeah. So, look, people don't pick tags to include in sort of the 'standard repertoire' based on them being boring. So most tags at least have some good level of interest, musically. So that was cool. Your first, your first experience where you're on the hook, if you don't have it, it's not going to happen, and then a chord rings and you're like, "Wow, that's wild." You know, that's the biggest part of it. I mean, I— the community is certainly a big part too. Yeah. The people around were great and super encouraging through that process.

Kevin: Now when I — when I joined the Silk City Chorus at the time, this is in, the era when the four singers in Men in Black were all in our chorus. So Tony Nasto was singing bass with us. Ray Johnson, I — actually, Ray Johnson was not part of the chorus, but he did help a lot. But then, Kurt [correction: Karl] absolutely sang bass with us, you know, for different things. And, Oliver sang lead for the chorus. So, those guys obviously had a lot of energy, momentum; it was certainly helpful in that experience too.

Megan: [00:07:06] Yeah, there's something about barbershop that ups your level of responsibility for the musical sound compared to something like a church choir. Like there are obviously very high-level church choirs, but there's something about like, "Oh, I have to know my part. And I have to know my part if I'm singing a tag." Like, and then to feel that harmony, like being a thing that you helped create. It's really cool.

Kevin: [00:07:29] Right. And, you know again, they, like Voices United rehearse in a church. And so, there are spaces in those buildings where when you do a tag, just the acoustics of the space sort of amplify it. [laughs]

Megan: [00:07:46] Even this room right now, I'm like, [sings] "Ahhhh!"

Kevin: [00:07:49] Yeah, exactly. [both laugh]

Megan: [00:07:53] I'm like, "Oo, I don't know if that's good for the sound, but it's not what we got going today." But yeah. So yeah. A stairwell.

Kevin: [00:07:57] Yes.

Megan: [00:07:58] A hallway little enclave.

Kevin: [00:08:02] Exactly. Exactly. Exactly. So yeah. So the sound connecting and happens is just very cool.

Megan: [00:08:08] Nice. So how long did you sing with Silk City Chorus? You know, did you go to contests? Like, tell me a little bit about your time with them.

Kevin: [00:08:15] Sure. So the Manchester Connecticut chapter, which Silk City is the traditional men's voice chorus, or, you know, men's register/lower register chorus. I was with them for about 12 years. I mean, the chorus was rehearsing like 25 minutes from my house, so it's convenient, you know, so they were close by. And we had a decent amount of regional success when I first joined the chorus; we were typically going to be in district contests — well, certainly in the Yankee division, we were finishing first, pretty consistently on an annual basis, and then within the Northeastern District, you know, we were usually in the top three or four in that era. So, a decent sounding chorus. Now the scores collectively in the district were lower at that time than they are now. So we might've been singing collectively in, you know, high sixties, low seventies, but that's still singing respectfully, right. It's singing well and having moments that are really cool. The chorus had a very active pattern of regular sectionals and rehearsals. We had coaches coming in on a steady flow, from a variety of angles to work with us.

Kevin: [00:09:44] Probably the highlight for the ensemble, though, has been their annual show. Pretty well known in the region, I think for a couple of reasons. One, in terms of talent brought in, Manchester has always brought in two top five international quartets to every show deliberately because the show is usually Mark Luther King Jr. weekend, mid-January. You're going to have weather. So, you don't want to book the one top quartet, and they can't get there because their flight can't get there so they get two from opposite ends to come in. And if one can't make it, odds are the other can, so at least you get one of the two. Now the whole time I was there, we generally got both, but obviously it provided a lot of talent on stage. The other is — so, Silk City from its start has had a combination of strong emcees who could manage a theme show very well, strong audio and lighting partners who could handle the theatrics of a stage environment in a high school auditorium, and then everything from really good craftsmen who could build awesome sets around different themes and then a team of, usually at least a half a dozen, super creative people who could write a script that take like eight songs that didn't seem like they belong together, and somehow they told a story.

Megan: [00:11:12] Now they're on a plane.

Kevin: [00:11:13] Right. Exactly. Exactly. We've done incredibly wild things. One year we did an arrangement of "Imagination" where that turned into, "It was all a dream" scene, so it flowed that way. We did a, in combination with UConn's Ballard School of Puppetry, we did a puppet show complete

with a couch that was a puppet where the cushions like opened as a mouth and talked. Hilarious because Main Street was there that year. And Tony DiRosa was having the conversation on the couch. [laughs]

Megan: [00:11:50] Yeah, but I bet he loved it.

Kevin: [00:11:51] Oh, he, he ate it up. Absolutely. Yeah. No, it was brilliant. It was brilliant. We did a show where we were the keys of the keyboard, a computer keyboard. So each of us, one of us was a letter. And we then morphed songs to fit that theme. You know, I was the letter "E" and I was you know, just being enamored with the letter "W and "W" was getting annoyed. So we sang, "Don't Blame 'E'" yes, corny jokes throughout the whole thing.

Megan: [00:12:25] But creative and like committed to the bit.

Kevin: [00:12:28] Absolutely. Absolutely. The show they did last year before I switched over to VU, we brought in a local Celtic cover band, and the entire show was in an Irish pub. And there was just this flow of male-voice chorus singing and then mixed-voice chorus singing, and then mixed chorus would sing with the band and then the band would play by themselves. And it was just this flow of music that had, I think, the audience feeling like they were in a pub —

Megan: [00:12:52] I was there; it was awesome

Kevin: [00:12:55] —and we're just kicking it down and it's fun. Yeah. So that was a huge draw to being a part of it. And so, yeah, so 12 years, I sang with the lower register bass clef voices. Schedule got in the way. They rehearsed weekly on a weeknight; life just got crazy. With Everyone in Harmony, they formed the mixed voice chorus, Mosaic, that was rehearsing one to two Sundays a month. That was much easier for me. So then I switched over to sing with Mosaic. So I was singing mixed harmony for the last six or seven years I was there.

Megan: [00:13:28] Yeah. You must've been at Mosaic pretty close to its forming?

Kevin: [00:13:30] Yeah, I think the year after they formed, I joined.

Megan: [00:13:33] Cool. Very nice. And what — you started to talk a little bit about like going to contests, like what was your first like district contest like?

Kevin: [00:13:43] So the first district contest was chorus only. So it's incredibly helpful to have a number of other people around you, surrounding you for your first experience. It's super nerve wracking, you know, not knowing what to expect, but everybody else does. But the chorus community was really solid in making sure that new members understood, "All right, this is what we're going to go into. This is what to expect. This is, you know, how to handle different scenarios and how to get

through different things." So it was— it's certainly a bonding experience for the ensemble in a unique way. We're singing well, so that felt good, right? The whole performance aspect of what we were doing felt good. The sets that we would do, the combined pieces we would do made sense together, worked well together. So that, yeah, that first experience was exciting and a lot of fun.

Megan: [00:14:33] At what point did you start quartet singing? Because you said, you know, singing with a chorus, you know, this is kind of the experience. At what point did you sing in a quartet for the first time?

Kevin: [00:14:42] So in my barbershop career, I've been in two quartets and both of them, I think the last one it was easily 15 years ago. So it was early in my barbershopping life that I did it. And honestly, in both cases, the quartets were really just to have fun. We wanted to quartet and, you know, people who enjoyed being around each other. So that was fun. We were good enough to qualify for district, not good enough to be in the 10. So sitting in that probably upper 60 range score-wise. So, you know, again, respectable singing. At first, kind of stuck with some tried and true classic barbershop, you know, easy things to work with and then started branching out and got into like, you know, vocal jazz, like Opus One that has plenty of challenges and things in it. We did Vocal Spectrum's arrangement of "Cheer Up Charlie." Absolutely my favorite song; in all of barbershop it's my favorite song. And I had fun with that, so that was very cool.

Megan: [00:15:55] What part did you sing in your quartet?

Kevin: [00:15:56] I was singing bass, and honestly, toward the tail end of the second quartet, that's probably where I started to fade out a little bit. My range — the bottom end of the register is tough in a bass clef-voiced quartet.

Megan: [00:16:13] It's low.

Kevin: [00:16:14] It's super low.

Megan: [00:16:16] And that's like "the cool thing."

Kevin: [00:16:18] Right. And you don't want to lip sync a third of a chart. So yeah. So I was singing bass with those. Since then, you know, I've always said I'd be happy to quartet. I'd love to quartet with people. Usually the barrier, quite frankly, is time. Four people that have schedules that align when you can all get together and rehearse on a regular basis [where] it's not taking away from eight other things that everybody's already doing. That's the hard part. You know, the singing together is the easy part. You know, as much as people talk about the challenges of picking charts as a quartet, even that's easier than scheduling.

Megan: [00:16:54] Yep. It's, I think it's the bane of most friend groups and like any activity or hobby, yeah. I sing in a quartet and the only thing that keeps us, you know, moving is that we meet at the same time every week, right? Always. And like, that's just the norm, you know, and that's tough.

Kevin: [00:17:12] Right, exactly. It is.

Megan: [00:17:14] But, can you think of a time as— so you sang in two quartets early on in your career and you mentioned, you know, liking the kind of 'ownership' of tag singing. Can you think of a time like as a quartet or tag singer where that felt especially like memorable, where you either felt like particularly proud or like that really sticks in your mind?

Kevin: [00:17:36] Here's where I'm going to shift a little bit.

Megan: [00:17:38] Okay! I love it.

Kevin: [00:17:38] Yeah, and I sent you a last minute message: Harmony Brigade.

Megan: [00:17:45] Yeah. let's talk about Harmony Brigade! [laughs]

Kevin: [00:17:48] Because I mean, honestly, in the quartets, I was never sort of the 'leader' in the quartet. I was there as a voice and just thought, "Oh, it's a great experience." But Harmony Brigade was what allowed me to immerse myself in an intense environment, just quartet.

Megan: [00:17:48] Mm-hmm. And also it's only one weekend. So, like, the scheduling problems of—

Kevin: [00:18:14] Performance is only a weekend. Rehearsing is nine months of agony.

Megan: [00:18:19] But. Yeah. But it's just you.

Kevin: [00:18:21] It is just you. Yeah. And you and your learning.

Megan: [00:18:23] The scheduling goes away.

Kevin: [00:18:24] Exactly. The scheduling is easier. You know, you know when the rally weekend is, you just block it off.

Megan: [00:18:28] And you still get to participate in the quartetting. But tell me about your first brigade.

Kevin: [00:18:34] So my first brigade was Harmony Brigade. It's the base clef-voiced brigade in the Northeast. and was singing base at that time in that brigade. And this was, I think, their, probably their fourth or fifth year already. So they— there was enough experience in the people who were running it that it didn't have the early challenges a lot of brigades do of figuring out what they want to be. And

the fact that first of all, having people seek you out, saying, "I want to sing with you," is really affirming and helps build this community of supporting each other through a process. So that was good. Having to remind yourself, cause I can be a pretty competitive person, that the competition aspect of brigade is, it's not real. We make it, we pretend that it's real, right? And yes, you want to sing really well. You want to perform, but let's be honest. You know the one that decides to bring a case of the favorite beer of the judging quartet is probably going to end up somewhere in the top three.

But no, but it was great to work intensely on a piece where you knew those other three voices were solid on what they did. You didn't have to worry about somebody didn't do their homework, and that makes a huge difference in an art form like barbershop, where you're so reliant on all four voices being 'on' to make it work. The selection of charts are a lot of fun — as much as I complained about how challenging they are to learn — they're a lot of fun. There have been only a few, and I can't even name them that I would say, "Yeah, I wasn't a big fan of that one." Most of them, I've been a huge fan of the charts that I've been selected. So the type of music you're doing is great. The people you're singing with is great, the delivery is awesome at a whole different level.

So yeah, you know, that, I think that's the first place where I really had to start pushing myself individually to say, "I need to focus on constant improvement as a performer." You know in a chorus, you can hide a little bit. You shouldn't, but you can. Quartet you can't. So, and a quartet with other people that are relying on you knowing what you're doing, you absolutely can't hide, so that's kind of what's developed my own approach to it, of wanting to constantly improve and constantly get better at what I'm doing.

Megan: [00:21:04] Yeah. And there's something I think about brigading too, that, to me, captures barbershop so well, right? This being able to sing with anybody and just kind of putting together four voices because you're in the same spot or because you sought each other out, right? Like that you can make music on these shared charts like so easily in the moment, but like that represents all of that work up to that point.

Kevin: [00:21:29] Yeah. On that level, it's polecats on steroids, right?

Megan: [00:21:31] Yes. [both laugh]

Kevin: [00:21:34] You know, to that end— but then the performance aspect. I think the trouble polecats have is people just get so comfortable with them that they'll get sloppy in the way they sing them, you know? And they'll just— yeah, I want to be a lax singer; I don't want to be a sloppy singer. Brigade doesn't let you do that.

Megan: [00:21:50] Right. It's harder. It's more intense. And there's a slight competition aspect to it that pushes you.

Kevin: [00:21:59] Yeah. It's the— and the charts in brigade are the first time that I actually felt like I had to start breaking down my learning in chunks of pieces, right? Chorus pieces, because of the repetition and working a lot as an ensemble on different pieces, you can try to kind of learn the thing end to end and then work on your segments or sections that aren't quite right. With brigade where it's all on you, "Okay. I've got to learn, you know, up through measure 58, I've got to focus on that one chunk and get it down and then I can move to the next chunk." Ironically, it's helped me a lot with Voices United because that's how I've worked our chorus charts.

Megan: [00:22:35] Me right now with "ABC." [laughs]

Kevin: [00:22:40] We're singing that together!

Megan: [00:22:41] Which I'm very excited about getting to sing with you. Cause I like, know you as a person, but like we stand very far away. So I'm like, "Ooh, yeah, I get to sing with Kevin, yeah!" That piece is deceptively easy.

Kevin: [00:22:54] It sure is, [laughs] as ABC.

Megan: [00:22:58] Yes! Why do the words change every time? Rhythms change every time? Yeah. And I'm the lead and I'm like, "I know how the melody goes," and I'm still drilling it chunk by chunk.

Kevin: [00:23:11] But we still have, what? A week to go!

Megan: [00:23:13] Yeah we've got a week; we got this! So I'm like looking at my questions to see kind of where we are at. You have also, I believe, gone to international contests, correct?

Kevin: [00:23:25] So that's a fun experience to share.

Megan: [00:23:29] Great. I would love to hear about it.

Kevin: [00:23:30] I have never been on stage in competition at international.

Megan: [00:23:33] Okay. Well, you've been—

Kevin: [00:23:34] But I've been on stage at international. [laughs] So, they did a thing in Pittsburgh — that was what, mid-2000, right? Around 2005, I think, I might be wrong. But they had— the brigade movement was trying to market as much as they could to get people excited. And so BHS gave Brigade the opportunity to do a harmony platoon. So pulling together, you know, a brigade-style environment and perform on the Saturday night show before the quartet finals. So we got a chance to learn "If You

Only Had a Mustache" as a group, work on it a couple of times during the week, and then we got to perform on the international stage in the Saturday night show before the quartet finals. So that was awesome. Performing in front of that large an audience is wild. Performing in an arena is very, very different than 98% of the places that we will ever perform in barbershop, so that's a whole different experience. So that was all good. And then yes, I was there for a whole week, so I got— and I deliberately— it was my first international, and I wanted to see everything, so I went to every contest segment. I went to the AIC show. I went to everything, so you're exhausted by the end of the week. But what I learned about myself is I want to sing, not watch. And that's why I haven't gone back to international since.

Megan: [00:25:06] Wow.

Kevin: [00:25:07] I have not been — money or time — but desperately would love to go to Harmony University for exactly the reason I'm talking about. I would rather spend the week singing myself and singing with other people than watching other people perform. They're great. They're brilliant. It's amazing entertainment. And I would never knock that for the people that enjoy it. It's just not what I'm looking for as a performer.

Megan: [00:25:30] And, so Harmony University is a goal for you?

Kevin: [00:25:32] [indiscipherable] Yeah, that'd be a bucket list item would be to go to Harmony University at some point in the future.

Megan: [00:25:36] Yeah. Maybe they'll move it closer.

Kevin: [00:25:39] [laughs]

Megan: [00:25:43] Denver's tough.

Kevin: [00:25:44] Denver's hard.

Megan: [00:25:46] New Orleans was okay, but Denver's tough. Yeah. So having, you know, been a barbershopper for over 20 years, right, and like having all of these experiences, how would you say that barbershop has changed since you first started?

Kevin: [00:26:02] So, the art form itself continues to move. Unfortunately, to the separation in excitement of members of BHS. There are those that want to cling, right, our kibbers ["Keep it Barbershop-ers"], they want to cling to what was through maybe the 1950s or 1960s, and that's barbershop, that's 'real' barbershop to them, and anything else is not. But then there's been these evolutions that— it's funny, sometimes even the evolutions that people that would call themselves kibbers think are fine were evolutions at the time. The Boston Common were an evolution in the way

the art form was performed, yet many people think of them as 'classic barbershop.' Okay, fine. That was stretching the umbrella a little bit further in their era. And we just, we continue to do that. So I would absolutely say that we've morphed, we've changed; the variety of pieces that we do is much more widespread. The number of quartets and choruses getting charts written for them specifically is light years from what it was when I first joined. Most people were working from the BHS catalog and pulling what they wanted. Not so much anymore with a lot of ensembles. So that's that full change.

Kevin: [00:27:19] Biggest piece though, flat out is "Everyone in Harmony." Absolutely the biggest change. I am a huge fan in part because the greatest moment for me in barbershop happened only because "Everyone in Harmony" happened. So, we have four kids: our oldest daughter, our second daughter, our third daughter who identifies as non-binary, and our son who is trans. And so it was, you know... you know, would be identified female at birth. And so when we had, at the time what we thought were four daughters, and I was singing in a bass clef ensemble, I thought there was never a chance any of my kids would be singing with me on the risers. And "Everyone in Harmony" happens probably halfway through our son's transition. And I was blessed to have a chorus that was fully open and welcoming of the change. And so the two of us sang in a bass clef ensemble together on the risers, on a show together, in contests together. Something I never thought would ever happen, you know, while the kids were growing up. So that was super special. It's super meaningful. It's also the change that's led me to realize that mixed voice is where I belong, mixed voice is where I want to be. Reality is, I could comfortably sing bass or baritone in mixed voice, so I have the ability to move based on, you know, where the need is. So I have a lot more flexibility in what we do, but realistically the communities operate very differently. And not that one's right or wrong; they're just different, and the type of community that I'm looking for happens to reside in a mixed voice ensemble. So yeah, "Everyone in Harmony," huge change. I mean, you could talk about other changes that happened: BHS moving from Kenosha, Wisconsin, down to Nashville. To be honest, as a member, it really didn't impact me directly at all. I knew it impacted staff; and that's like— you know, for us as the singers, not so much. You know, so there's those types of things.

Kevin: [00:27:38] I still think the one thing that hasn't changed is that I want to see change: It's just general public awareness. And it's been this sort of albatross around barbershop's neck for ages, and I think we thought when the Pitch Perfect movies came out, everybody was focused on acapella. "Here's our opportunity! Here's our chance," right? And somehow, we just couldn't convert that into what we did, so I think there's still an opportunity there. And the thing that has to feed into that is the organization has to realize how people much younger than me now experience their lives. You know the folks that have been around in the hobby for 30, 40, 50 years, you know, there were plenty of them that were single working parents. So the second parent was home with the kids full time, so you going out every weekday night to a rehearsal was not a deal [breaker]. There were people who were literally

working 40 hour jobs, and it was only 40 hours, and they were coming home at the same time every night, so that was fine. And I think there was just— there were far less options or avenues that people could travel to experience the different aspects of their life that they wanted to live out. That piece has broadened: work days have gotten far longer than they ever should be, and we've got, you know, two working parents, we have kids; schedules that are off the charts for things, and so people's schedules are so busy that, you know, to go to something every Monday night at 7 PM just isn't happening now. I think that's the barrier and that's what has to change. And to this day kind of hasn't yet.

Megan: [00:31:34] Yeah, that's an interesting point. I think, like I found barbershop in high school, so I have worked my millennial life around the fact that that's like a value that exists, but I can't imagine like if I already had like a job and was stressed and like didn't prioritize adding a thing, like that that would be really challenging.

Kevin: [00:31:54] Yeah. Now, I mean, certainly the work that we're dealing with, you know, Harmony College Northeast's expansion is awesome. I want to see it get even bigger. I think there's a lot of work that local ensembles and chapters have to do to figure out how to morph the way they do Youth in Harmony to get to that point. There needs to be a lot more interaction with the middle school, high school corridor and choral directors and you know, introducing things to get people excited about it. Cause yeah, you're right. I mean, if you grow up with it, then it sort of just becomes part of the life that you expect. That's a different aspect.

Megan: [00:32:27] That's a good, yeah, that's a good point. So you mentioned your kids, do they sing barbershop or like how many— are they barbershop brats or are they, you know, singers?

Kevin: [00:32:38] Our son was the only one who did barbershop; the other three did not. Now they're all musical. So all of them sang, all of them played instruments. So our oldest was a soprano voice in SATB ensembles, you know, school, you know, throughout, and she played flute. Our second would sing, kind of straddled that line between upper end alto, lower end soprano, so could sing anywhere in that range, but then decided to focus on instrumental and went with euphonium first, which then led to tuba and sousaphone.

Megan: [00:33:12] Heck yeah.

Kevin: [00:33:13] Because the instrumental director at the elementary school in town was so focused on breaking stereotypes and wanted female-identifying students playing low brass and wanted male-identifying students playing flute and piccolo just to show that you can do the instrument you want to do. Don't let these other things... So, yeah, so she went that direction. The third one started on trumpet and then switched to French horn, and you know, they played really well across the board. And then our son sang lead in a bass clef voiced barbershop arrangement. Also has learned ukulele

self-taught, enjoys playing a lot of stuff to that. So, you know, those are, those are the kids. So they all did things musically. Just went in different directions, and I never was going to force them. I was never going to tell them, oh, you got to do this. You know, they were exposed to it throughout their lives. Absolutely. And if one of them said, "Hey, I'm interested in checking it out," yeah, come along.

Megan: [00:34:24] Sunday, 4 PM.

Kevin: [00:34:25] Exactly. Exactly.

Megan: [00:34:26] Is your wife musical?

Kevin: [00:34:27] No, she jokes. She absolutely is not. Because we have four kids, and all of us would perform, and we do things in church and whatever, you know, people would joke that we were the VonWilliams family and, you know, that kind of thing. In that environment, my wife would always say she's Max the Manager. [both laugh] She's a coordinator. She's the organizer: "I'm going to keep everybody on track, but I am not going to perform."

Megan: [00:34:49] Nice. So recently you've joined Voices United Chorus, a mixed harmony chorus in the Southern New England chapter. Can you tell me a little bit about what that experience has been like? Like what drew you to Voices United?

Kevin: [00:35:02] So "wild" would be the easy word to use for the experience. But so look, I've known the VU for quite a while. I've known, you know, Vocal Revolution, Vocamotion for quite a while as well, being in the Northeastern district. Yeah, but brigades between the men's brigade and the mixed harmony brigades have some—a lot—of people who are in VU already. Including my first brigade quartet was with Chad Putka, our director, so there's that. But yeah, so knew it was out there. Distance was a challenge. It's about 90 minutes from my house to rehearsal. It helps that it is a Sunday afternoon, and that it's not necessarily every week. That helps. But so that was always a barrier was, "Okay, I'm singing with somebody 25 minutes from me. And to go 90 minutes to do this was just a thing. Realistically, even maybe slightly before pandemic, there started to be a little bit of a culture shift in the ensemble I was with. They got away from PVIs. They got away from sectionals and duetting and the things that really drive you forward as an ensemble. Pandemic kind of pushed that even further back, and emerging out of it, I gave it a couple of years and said, "This doesn't feel right. It's not challenging me and pushing you in a way" that I felt I needed to go. So long talk with my wife about the impact on you know, I have a side hustle in ministry. So my Sunday mornings are shot. You know, she took a look at the schedule for the year and said, "Yep, I'll fully support you. Do what you want. Saturdays are mine, your butt's mine."

Megan: [00:36:50] It's all about balance.

Kevin: [00:36:51] Right, right. And we treated it as this, "Try it for a season, see how it goes." So I made the decision to audition late. I made the decision to do this right around right around Harmony College Northeast. It would have been like the July timeframe, which means auditioning at the tail end of the prior season was done, everybody's kind of often scattered for the summer, but was forceful enough in my own push to say, "I need the audition track. I need the chart. You got to give me a chance to work on this now. So I have something to work on." So we start up in late August, and I can come in and kind of have a place. So that's what it felt like this time.

Megan: [00:37:39] It's crazy you've only been around Voices United for like four months. [both laugh] Just to timestamp this interview. That's crazy. There is not a Voices United that exists in my head that doesn't have Kevin in it. Truly, I mean that.

Kevin: [00:37:58] Oh man. No, but and then I get here and not only is the musical approach really solid and driving and pushing you to do things and and in great ways, but the culture flat out is exactly what I needed to find. A parent of kids that fall on the LGBTQ+ spectrum, a person who has a side hustle ministry with a liberal denomination that, you know, honestly understands that, you know, everyone is a beloved child of God and you can't change that, you know? And so we need to be supportive and— and we use the term, actually in church, we use the term, it's "Love God, love others, the rest is details." So if you're loving God, you're loving others, you're doing what you're supposed to do, right? So am I loving others? And honestly VU loves others in a way that is unique to its culture and stuff. And so being enveloped in that it was big, but the biggest piece in this whole thing has been the excitement of other people that I'm here and people like genuinely, "I'm thrilled you're here, I appreciate you, you're here, this is awesome, it's so fun to sing with you!" and that type of affirmation means a lot to every individual that's here. And that doesn't necessarily happen in every ensemble.

Megan: [00:39:24] I've sung in choruses where people don't know my name, you know, and not big ones, like reasonable-sized ones.

Kevin: [00:39:32] Right. You know, or know a little bit about you at least. Or you know, or if they're doing tags, they're going to want to invite you over, "Come on! Sing this tag, this is fun!" you know? So that's been helpful. Like I said before, I mean mixed voice was where I belonged, in part because bass plus notes are in my range.

Megan: [00:39:55] Right. It's a higher bass.

Kevin: [00:39:57] Yeah, yeah, for most songs. You've got a couple that stretch at the bottom end.

Megan: [00:40:01] It's better to have like three notes you can't hit than three pages of notes you can't hit.

Kevin: [00:40:06] Absolutely, so that helps too. The types of charts that we're doing absolutely draw off of who I am as a person. There are people out there who are the logical thinking, engineering mind, tactical, structural people in the world. And we need a ton of them to do all the great things that they do. And there's a lot of them that are phenomenal singers, right? I am not that. I am hugely emotional. A lot of what we can get out of me as a singer is going to be driven by how much emotion we can extract out of a piece. And so when we start diving into, you know, we start diving into pieces and I start looking at the charts that we're doing... Yeah, I'm getting super emotional in the middle of nearly, no, every song, [both laugh] real secretly every song. You know it's pulling so much from me in such an amazing way.

Megan: [00:41:07] Very cool. That answers my question, "What makes VU special?" But if there's anything else that you didn't mention, [both laugh] love getting to hear about it. So you've mentioned some other parts of your life that kind of impact your musical philosophy and kind of like back and forth. How would you say barbershop has impacted other areas of your life, whether those are relationships, your career, your faith, your personal growth, or like vice versa? Are there any parts of your personal life that you like especially try to bring into your barbershop life?

Kevin: [00:41:37] Sure. I wish I could say that my life was a direct path, and I know nobody's is. Mine is more like switchbacks, like all over the place. From starting and bailing out on college to my career path, starting in one direction and what I do today isn't even close to what I did when I started working to, you know, being part of a local church community in the town that I grew up in to now working for a church that's 45 minutes away in a way that I never would have expected, right? So all of this has shifted and changed. And so what you realize when you look back and you see that is that full aspect of people coming to your life for a season and they're there and, you know, then they're off because you're onto something else. Barbershop has been the constant. Barbershop has been the family that the person that I met 20 years ago is still a friend, is still somebody I like, is still somebody I interact with, and it only keeps growing as I get involved with different ensembles and different aspects, and doing brigade is new and, you know, branching out and getting to know these people. And so, you know, if you look at my Facebook feed and you look at my friends list, it's 85% barbershoppers. It's— I joked to myself a couple of weeks ago, I'm looking at it and looking at, you know, the friends recommendations, and I'm like, "It they have 50 or more friends that are the same as mine, they're a barbershopper. So yep. That one's good."

Megan: [00:43:16] You make the cut. You pass the peer review.

Kevin: [00:43:18] Right, right. So yeah, I mean, that's been the biggest piece is that the people that I feel like are kind of my 'forever friends' and people that will be around in my life as long as they want to be a part of my life are in my life. There was a very personal barbershop moment that impacted me

pretty heavily. So, my father passed away in 2009. When he passed away, he was chief of the University of Connecticut Fire Department. And a long-standing tradition in the fire service of kind of formality and structure of certain things that they would do in a service. There were certain things that my father absolutely wanted. It was wild that the fire department created an operational plan for his funeral, but they did. So everything from the cross ladder towers of the American flag draped as they, you know, drove under with his coffin; coffin the last mile rode on the top of the fire engine to the church where the service was done. And, yeah because he was a chief at UConn—that's the State of Connecticut—so there were state troopers everywhere. There were other fire chiefs and people from other fire departments. I couldn't tell you how many people there are. It was massive. But, one of the things that they wanted was part of the service was to sing the "National Anthem." And so I went back to my chorus and we pulled the VLQ [Very Large Quartet] specifically of voices that we knew and we had confidence in, were going to deliver it well. And so I sang bass in that VLQ with the other guys that were there as part of my father's funeral service. That's the type of commitment that people in this community have to support each other. You know, somebody passed away and you need music for that service: There will be people there that will get it done, you know?

There was one of the local, more competitive quartets in the chapter I was in before wanted opportunities to sing and perform, and I said, "Hey, look, what if we do a house concert?" So my mom has this crazy house. It started as a log house — still is — they went to do a kitchen expansion and new house ate the old house. So it's got this massive great room, this massive dining area. And so we said, "Let's do a house concert. You guys perform." And then I was able to pull like three other quartets to come. And then we said, "Hey, look, why don't we have the people that come provide some donations and have that go to Youth in Harmony?" and through just that one thing, we were able to sponsor two kids to go to HXNE. And, you know, again, that's the barbershop community. It's like, "How can I take the skill, this ability that I have and make other people's lives better through it?" So that's how it's impacted me is it's driven home for me that I need to continue that pay it forward journey. I need to continue to do things that make life better for others.

Megan: [00:46:30] Yeah. People show up. Like barbershoppers show up. My chorus sang my mom's service when she passed as well. And like, I remember just sending a text like "Tell people to show up. Like, I can't plan it, but like be there," and like they were there. And just like that is so special, and also so special to have a thing that your hobby can give in those moments. Like not to say, I don't know, but competitive hacky sackers aren't coming to the service, you know, to like be doing something where you're making something that like can offer that support and that warmth when it's needed is really special too.

Kevin: [00:47:08] Yeah, it is. So, I mean, so it changes your life in constant interaction, in constant support. And then the drive that it fuels in you to give at that level for other people.

Megan: [00:47:22] Absolutely. So what... well you answered that question, I guess, which is like, "What has it been like to have this as such a big part of your life, and what has been really impactful about it?" What would you say to somebody who like has never sung barbershop before? Like, what is the feeling like of being in that community and making that music for someone who has no frame of reference for like what we do?

Kevin: [00:47:46] Right. Well, I'll start with where have you been all your life? Why are you not doing this? Right.

Megan: [00:47:50] You, you watching this.

Kevin: [00:47:53] No, I think there's, I think there's a couple of things. I think we all inherently reflect this in different ways, but with the same message that you can't explain it until you experience it. As much as I want to come up with the words that describe, it's so difficult to describe a first rung chord or performing a chart end to end cleanly, and knowing that you were part of this moment that you're in, it's not going to happen again, that same way. You know, so to that end it's hard. What I would say is: First of all, yes, give yourself grace that you've ignored this type of music for a while. That's okay. It's okay. Second, don't think you have— don't think it's this overwhelming thing, right? Come to a rehearsal of an ensemble and try singing one tag, right? You know, no commitments, nothing. You've never— you haven't locked into anything. You've just shown up and said, "I'm willing to check this out. I'm willing to learn what this is about and kind of hear it for the first time live," If you've never heard it before. And then yeah, you know, try a tag, you're going to be able to learn it pretty quickly. They're not long. Well, some are long, but you won't struggle a long time. People are not that sadistic that they're going to start doing a real long tag. But they're going to start you out with something that's going to encourage you. So start out with that tag, sing it and see how it feels. It's not about how it sounds it's about how it feels, so there's that. And then I think the other piece is, if you've never gone to see a barbershop performance, go, you know. Next May, 2026, come see VU! But yeah, come to see a performance, and at least you'll hear it live, and you can start to understand what makes it different. And I guess the last piece of that is it ain't even your father's barbershop, let alone your grandfather's barbershop today, right? What we sing, what we perform, what we do are crazy charts that people would never think are barbershop charts, but they are, and why? It's because of the way that close harmony sound fits, the way a certain melody is going to move, and that harmony is going to pivot around that melody. So yeah, just give yourself the opportunity to try it.

Megan: [00:50:35] That's so beautiful. And I think that captures, I think, really also the spirit of this project, right? Which is like, you are an everyday person, right? Like you are not, you know, you don't have 10 music degrees. Like this is a thing that you do as a part of your whole life. Right. And like that is unique.

Kevin: [00:50:52] Now if I had a music degree, people would be looking at me to direct.

Megan: [00:50:55] Well, we'll keep you on sound for now. So to close out, do you have a favorite tag? You've mentioned that you love to tag sing and like, do you have a favorite or a couple favorites?

Kevin: [00:51:09] So I haven't historically been able to teach tags, not necessarily good at it. I will join in tags all the time. But "Cheer Up Charlie's" probably my favorite tag.

Megan: [00:51:24] On, do you have a particular part that you sing?

Kevin: [00:51:26] I sing bass on it, so.

Megan: [00:51:28] Can you grace us with a couple lines?

Kevin: [00:51:30] I could try that. Okay. So let's see. [sings] Just be glad you're you. I love you. [ends singing] So it's better with a bari moving around it.

Megan: [00:51:49] But it's also barbershop, even without that. That's a barbershop, baby.

Kevin: [00:51:52] Yeah, oh, it is barbershop. It is very barbershop. And it's funny cause the tag existed before the chart. The tag was around for ages, and then finally, yeah, it was a David Wright chart, I'm pretty sure that he did for Vocal Spectrum. They finally wrote that. It's awesome.

Megan: [00:52:08] Awesome.

Kevin: [00:52:08] But yeah.

Megan: [00:52:08] Is there anything about your story that I didn't ask or that you would like to share?

Kevin: [00:52:13] No. As you can tell, I can yap for hours, more than people actually want to listen.

Megan: [00:52:18] Listen, if we leave this interview, we have to go do risers.

Kevin: [00:52:21] No, I have to do sound. That's my outfit.

Megan: [00:52:23] I have to do risers.

Kevin: [00:52:27] Well, lifting a speaker out there on a stand is not easy. So no, I don't think there's anything, you know, specifically that I can think of that's you know, that's outside of this. I just think

that this, this world that we're a part of is amazing. My one wish, my one dream is Sweet Ads, HI, BHS, get your act together and all be one.

Megan: [00:52:51] And that's that on that. Well, thank you so much for talking to me, Kevin. This has been really great.